

Overview & Scrutiny Committee

MINUTES of the OPEN section of the Overview & Scrutiny Committee held on Tuesday 20 January 2026 at 6.30 pm at Ground Floor Meeting Room G02A - 160 Tooley Street, London SE1 2QH

PRESENT: Councillor Ian Wingfield (Chair)
Councillor Irina Von Wiese (Vice- Chair)
Councillor Laura Johnson
Councillor Richard Leeming
Councillor Jason Ochere
Councillor Bethan Roberts

**OTHER
MEMBERS
PRESENT:**

**OFFICER
SUPPORT:** Amit Alva, Scrutiny Officer

1. APOLOGIES

Apologies for absence were received from Councillor Stephanie Cryan, Martin Bracknell (Education Co-opted Member), Councillor Esme Hicks, Councillor Martin Seaton, Councillor Victor Chamberlain and Councillor Suzanne Abachor.

2. NOTIFICATION OF ANY ITEMS OF BUSINESS WHICH THE CHAIR DEEMS URGENT

The Chair notified the committee that the item on Cabinet consultation with OSC on the proposed budget – formulation of scrutiny recommendations would be taken first and that the recommendations from the previous day's budget meeting would be revisited.

3. DISCLOSURE OF INTERESTS AND DISPENSATIONS

Councillor Richard Leeming declared that his spouse is the Chair of Partnership, Southwark.

4. CABINET CONSULTATION WITH OSC ON THE PROPOSED BUDGET - FORMULATION OF SCRUTINY RECOMMENDATIONS

The committee received this item as a continuation of the previous day's budget scrutiny meeting, to agree and refine the Overview & Scrutiny Committee's recommendations on the proposed council budget. Printed copies of a draft list of recommendations, arising from the discussion on 19 January, were circulated to members.

The Chair reminded the committee that only Members present at the previous day's meeting should take part in agreeing the recommendations.

Clive Palfreyman, Strategic Director of Resources, attended for this item and confirmed that the discussion followed on directly from the previous day's session.

The committee then heard the following additional proposals from Councillor Irina Von-Wiese on behalf of the Liberal Democrat Group, in addition to the draft recommendations already circulated:

- Further to discussions yesterday on council tax increases impacting the cost of living, OSC recommends Southwark investigate the feasibility of further expanding and fine tuning CTR rates and eligibility, expanding support where possible.
- Based on the equalities impact assessment on fees and charges which notes the negative impact on equality and diversity, OSC believes that the Cabinet should review whether all the above-inflation increases are necessary even when they have a disproportionate effect on vulnerable groups and those with protected characteristics.
- As the Council relies more heavily on temporary accommodation, OSC recommends that the Council performs additional spot checks on all temporary accommodation to ensure that the Council is achieving value for money and providing appropriate accommodation.
- OSC suggests that the Council sets aside funding in order to roll out local hubs or 'One Stop Shops' across the borough to allow residents to access council services where they are and on their terms. This would provide some mitigation against the negative equalities impacts of the rise of council services fees and charges as residents would be able to access support more quickly rather than waiting until a situation deteriorates.

The committee then asked questions on the following themes:

The intent and feasibility of expanding and “fine-tuning” the Council Tax Reduction (CTR) scheme, including what specific gaps or groups might be in scope, the evidence base for change and the statutory consultation requirements.

- Whether the proposed CTR recommendation went beyond existing work already being undertaken by officers to bring more eligible residents into the scheme and to consolidate wider cost-of-living support.
- The practical and financial implications of checking all temporary accommodation, including whether a targeted approach (for example, focusing on out-of-borough placements) would be more realistic and cost-effective.
- The relationship between the proposed TA checks and existing work under the Good Landlord Plan and the role of the Housing Scrutiny Commission in examining TA standards and oversight in more depth.
- The level of evidence currently available on the impact of above-inflation fees and charges on equalities, and whether any immediate changes could realistically be made within the 2026–27 budget.
- The cost, scale and delivery model of proposed local hubs/one-stop shops, including whether these would be new premises or delivered through existing sites such as libraries and leisure centres.
- Clarification of a previously drafted recommendation relating to the Educational Psychology Team savings delay, and how that delay fitted with planned staffing changes and natural attrition.
- The robustness, governance and risk management arrangements around transformation and efficiency savings, including digital systems, procurement and the introduction of AI.
- The framing of the recommendation on the voluntary and community sector (VCS) to ensure it is deliverable and linked to outcomes as well as funding levels.

On Council Tax Reduction (CTR), Councillor Von-Wiese clarified that the intention was two-fold:

- to fine-tune the existing criteria so that eligible residents do not fall through the net; and
- to investigate the feasibility of expanding support to new groups of vulnerable residents, where evidence supports this.

Furthermore, the proposal was to undertake an investigation and review, not to pre-judge the outcome.

Members noted that the council already undertakes ongoing work to maximise take-up of CTR and queried whether there was evidence of specific groups currently excluded. Councillor Von-Wiese confirmed that the proposal was a general review rather than targeted at named groups and accepted that the outcome might be that no further expansion was feasible.

Clive Palfreyman explained that any substantive change to the Council Tax

Localisation scheme would require a statutory consultation process and could not be completed in time to affect the April 2026 budget. He suggested that broader cost-of-living support (including council tax, social tariffs on utilities and early engagement with residents in arrears) is already being consolidated and that the spirit of the recommendation could be taken forward as part of work planned over the next financial year.

The Chair summarised that, while immediate changes to CTR for 2026–27 were not feasible, the committee could recommend a review over the next 12 months, feeding into the following year's budget process.

On temporary accommodation (TA), Members queried whether carrying out checks on “all” TA was practical or affordable and whether it would still constitute “spot” checks. Councillor Von-Wiese accepted that the term “spot checks on all TA” was contradictory and agreed that the focus should be on ensuring that every TA placement is properly checked for quality and value for money, rather than relying only on paperwork and provider assurances.

Councillor Johnson raised concerns about the potential revenue implications of significantly increasing checks, particularly on out-of-borough TA, which can be more complex and costly to monitor. She suggested that a more targeted approach, especially where casework highlighted concerns, might be appropriate.

Councillor Ochere and other committee members proposed that this area would benefit from more detailed scrutiny by the Housing Scrutiny Commission, particularly in light of the Good Landlord Plan agreed by Cabinet. They suggested that the Commission examine:

- what checks already take place on TA.
- the feasibility and cost of strengthening those checks; and
- how any additional activity would link to existing work on temporary accommodation overspends and quality.

Clive Palfreyman informed the committee that TA is the council's largest overspend on the General Fund side and is under intense scrutiny through a Budget Recovery Board, including a focus on nightly paid accommodation and reducing unit costs (with around a 20% reduction achieved over the last year), also noting that:

- refusing a placement on value-for-money grounds does not necessarily reduce market prices, as other boroughs may still take the property; and
- there are already due-diligence checks on TA, particularly where the council uses its own stock or procures properties via formal frameworks.

It was confirmed that TA properties are visited by council officers before being let to families, and that existing processes include both quality and value-for-money considerations.

On the proposed recommendation about local hubs/one-stop shops, the committee noted that there would be revenue implications depending on the model adopted.

Councillor Von-Wiese explained that the proposal responded to longstanding resident requests for more locally accessible, non-digital routes to council services. She undertook to provide further written detail, including indicative costings, when submitting the recommendations electronically.

Clive Palfreyman drew attention to the council's Resident Experience Plan, which aims to make better use of existing public-facing buildings such as libraries and leisure centres, enabling residents to access support or digital self-service without creating entirely new sites. This may offer a more cost-efficient way of meeting the objectives behind the hubs' proposal.

The committee then reviewed the previously circulated list of recommendations. Points highlighted included:

- The Educational Psychology Team savings: Members sought clarity on how the proposed savings delay would operate in practice. It was explained that planned reductions in the team had been affected by retirements and staffing changes, and that the delay related to maintaining capacity for longer than initially planned.
- A cluster of recommendations on transformation and efficiency savings (originally bullets 4, 5 and 9) were considered for replacement by a single, more comprehensive recommendation drafted by Councillor Richard Leeming.

Councillor Leeming read out a consolidated recommendation on "Transformation and efficiency savings", proposing that the council should:

Prioritise cross-council transformation projects (e.g. procurement of digital platforms and better use of council-owned properties) to:

- improve resident experience and interaction with the council.
- make it easier for staff to do their jobs well.
- achieve efficiencies and financial savings.
- enable better cross-department collaboration.
- ensure decisions are based on data and evidence.
- address technical debt, obsolete systems and inefficient manual processes.
- Ensure transformation projects are supported by robust business cases and follow council governance processes.
- Ensure the council stays abreast of technological developments when procuring and deploying digital platforms and services.
- Monitor and report transformation savings by providing detailed updates on profiling and delivery, including revised timelines and assurance that the total Medium Term Financial Strategy (MTFS) savings target will be met.
- Monitor and report risk related to procurement of digital platforms and services, with regular reporting to OSC.
- Ensure ongoing investment in cyber-security infrastructure and skills to manage emerging threats.
- Continue to invest in digital skills for staff and residents.

Councillor Johnson proposed that the consolidated recommendation should explicitly reference the roll-out of Artificial Intelligence (AI) and the need to:

- monitor how AI is introduced across council departments.
- assess whether it delivers the intended efficiencies and service improvements; and
- capture feedback from staff and residents on its impact.

She also suggested clarifying that “data and evidence” should include qualitative feedback on user experience, not just quantitative performance data. Councillor Leeming agreed that references to AI and both qualitative and quantitative evidence could be incorporated.

The committee agreed in principle to adopt Councillor Leeming’s consolidated transformation recommendation, incorporating Councillor Johnson’s points on AI and qualitative evidence, and to strike out the previous separate bullets on digital transformation and related risks in favour of the new wording.

On the VCS recommendation, Clive Palfreyman suggested revised wording to make it more deliverable and outcome-focused. The committee agreed to amend the recommendation to read along the lines of:

“Review support and funding for the voluntary and community sector (VCS), recognising their value in delivering enhanced services and mitigating demand on statutory services. Consolidating VCS support and funding streams should realise improved outcomes for target groups.”

The committee agreed to work with officers to finalise the precise wording of all recommendations, including the new and amended ones, based on the discussion and emailed drafts from Members. The Chair confirmed that the finalised set of OSC budget recommendations would be agreed once the amendments had been incorporated.

5. SOUTHWARK 2030 GOAL - WELL RUN COUNCIL

The committee then considered the item on Southwark 2030 – Well Run Council, with a specific focus on the Council Delivery Plan (CDP) commitments and performance.

Rhona Cadenhead, Assistant Chief Executive, introduced the report, supported by Moshumi Bhadra, Strategy and Communities:

- The reports presented quarter 2 performance up to September 2025 against the CDP commitments, including a deeper dive on the “Well Run Council” goal, alongside the latest Residents Insight Survey findings.
- Compared to previous years, performance monitoring had been sharpened: lead officers now set out expected milestones and performance levels for

each quarter, which are then quality-assured by the Strategy team, Cabinet portfolio meetings, Leader/Chief Executive one-to-ones and the Council Leadership Team.

- There remained some work to do to ensure consistent application of Red/Amber/Green (RAG) ratings, as some services tend to be more cautious or self-critical than others.
- A new Chief Executive's performance dashboard had been developed, focusing on core service standards and operational performance. It was envisaged that this, together with an annual performance and four-year CDP round-up report, could be brought to OSC in March.

Members asked questions and made comments on the following themes:

- Fly-tipping removal performance, including:
 - why around 28% of incidents were not being removed within the 24-hour target.
 - the increase in monthly fly-tipping reports (from around 600 to 800); and
 - the proposal to change fly-tipping and graffiti removal targets from 24 to 48 hours (and significantly longer for some graffiti).
- Whether extending target times risked being seen as moving the goalposts rather than tackling underlying performance issues, and whether performance should be benchmarked against other boroughs.
- A reported dip in recycling performance (from around 36% to 34.4%) and whether contamination issues, or the introduction of new food waste recycling services, contributed to this.
- The actual satisfaction rate for call centres, given the report's reference to the council remaining committed to improvement.
- Progress on rail station accessibility, as the CDP referenced Peckham Rye and Nunhead, but Members noted that other stations in the borough (including North Dulwich, East Dulwich and the national rail station at Elephant and Castle) also had significant accessibility needs.
- Which CDP commitments were currently "at risk", and how this was reflected in the reporting structure.
- The ongoing challenges in meeting void turnaround targets for both major and minor voids.
- The development of housing advice surgeries co-located in family hubs, and how that related to wider support for rough sleepers and families at risk of homelessness, as well as links to other services such as financial support and SEND advice.

On fly-tipping, Moshumi confirmed that the reported performance showed that around 28% of fly-tipping incidents were not being cleared within the existing 24-hour target. She noted that:

- service requests for fly-tipping had risen, and
- she would seek further information from the service on whether the shift to a 48-hour target was intended to align with other London authorities' practice

or reflected a new strategic approach (for example, balancing removal with increased enforcement).

Officers undertook to obtain and share comparative data from other authorities and additional context on the rationale for the change in targets.

On recycling performance, Rhona explained that the service believed the quarter 2 dip to be a one-off anomaly rather than a trend and that they expected performance to rebound in quarter 3. The reasons, including any link to contamination or new food waste collections, were being investigated and would be closely monitored.

On call centre satisfaction, officers did not have the specific satisfaction percentage to hand but confirmed that customer surveys take place after calls. They agreed to provide the committee with the latest measured satisfaction rate outside the meeting.

With regard to station accessibility, officers explained that the CDP report could only refer to the specific commitments adopted in the delivery plan – in this case, improvements at Peckham Rye and Nunhead. This did not preclude work on other stations, but they were not all captured under the same commitment in this particular report.

On “at risk” CDP items, officers clarified that:

- the “areas of continued focus” section highlighted commitments where performance was not yet where the council wanted it to be; and
- a key example in the current report was the turnaround of void properties, where both major and minor voids were off-target despite a transformation programme underway to redesign processes.

On family hubs and housing advice, Rhona explained that co-locating housing advice surgeries in family hubs was additional to existing rough-sleeping and homelessness services. It aimed to support early intervention for families at risk of homelessness, using trusted settings where people already engage with services. Needs assessments had been used to tailor the offer of each hub to local communities, and there was a dedicated SEND-focussed hub.

Members linked this discussion back to earlier budget recommendations on local hubs and access to services, and officers confirmed that work under the Resident Experience plan was intended to broaden access through libraries, leisure centres and other community-based venues.

6. COUNCIL DELIVERY PLAN PERFORMANCE

This agenda item was covered in the previous agenda item no.5.

7. REFUGEES / BOROUGH OF SANCTUARY (TASK AND FINISH GROUP SETUP)

The committee then considered an item on Refugees – Borough of Sanctuary, introduced by Councillor Jasmine Ali, Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Children, Education and Refugees, supported by Stephen Douglass, Director of Stronger Neighbourhoods.

Councillor Ali informed the committee that it had been over a year since Southwark achieved Borough of Sanctuary status, and highlighted the following progress:

- Development of a strong partnership model across the voluntary and community sector (VCS), legal advice providers, libraries and schools.
- Southwark becoming the first local authority to have both Schools of Sanctuary and Libraries of Sanctuary, reflecting a whole-borough approach.
- Delivery of EVS workshops and practical outreach to support residents through the transition to a digital immigration system.
- Establishment of an Experts by Experience panel to ensure that the lived experience of refugees, asylum seekers and vulnerable migrants shapes service design.
- Recruitment of specialist resettlement workers and the creation of a housing surgery to address accommodation and welfare needs.
- A new funding arrangement with United St Saviour's to channel grants to the VCS more effectively and in closer to "real time".
- Establishment of a regular Safeguarding and Education Board, chaired by Councillor Ali, to ensure that issues such as school uniforms, safeguarding and access to education for new arrivals are addressed quickly.

Councillor Ali explained that the partnership had matured into a genuine collaborative model, rather than the council simply acting as a "mothership" to smaller organisations. Although there were robust discussions and occasional criticism, the shared aim of supporting refugees and migrants had produced strong joint working, including a shared sanctuary framework, public-facing communications work and an annual report.

Councillor Ali also referred to the wider political context, including:

- increasing national focus on immigration.
- far-right attempts to mobilise locally; and
- joint statements issued by the council leadership to reaffirm Southwark as a welcoming borough and to challenge hostile rhetoric and policy proposals from central government.

Stephen explained that activity under the Borough of Sanctuary programme was funded by central government grants, covering work with Afghans, Ukrainians and other resettled groups, also noting that:

- the only related cost not directly grant-funded was support for people with

No Recourse to Public Funds (NRPF), which is driven by statutory duties.

- around 300 people with NRPF (including children, families and adults with care needs) were currently being supported; and
- expenditure in this area was between £8–9 million, with a forecast overspend of around £1 million, driven by accommodation and cost-of-living pressures.

Councillor Ali stressed that this figure covered the overall support framework, including accommodation and service delivery, rather than cash given directly to individuals.

Stephen outlined the role of specialist refugee/resettlement workers, which includes wrap-around support such as:

- assistance with GP registration, setting up bank accounts and accessing welfare advice.
- signposting to language classes and employment support; and
- close working with MASH, early help and children's services where there are safeguarding or education issues.

The committee asked questions on the following themes:

- How the council is future-proofing its Borough of Sanctuary work against potential changes in central government funding or policy, and future changes in local political leadership.
- How the new safeguarding and education arrangements interface with existing multi-agency safeguarding structures, including the role of MASH and early help.
- How quickly issues identified by VCS partners or the Experts by Experience panel can be escalated and resolved in practice.

In response, Councillor Ali explained that Southwark is embedded in the Cities of Sanctuary network and wider London-wide structures, including work through London Councils (led on this agenda by Waltham Forest). A strong network of leaders and officers worked together to:

- share good practice.
- coordinate policy positions and public statements; and
- respond quickly to emerging national developments (for example, proposed changes by the Home Secretary).

Councillor Ali also suggested that this collective approach is a key part of future-proofing the Borough of Sanctuary work and maintaining a strong public stance that “everyone is welcome here”, regardless of changes at national level. On safeguarding and education.

Councillor Ali further explained that the dedicated board had been created in response to concerns raised by VCS partners, and that it brings together unaccompanied asylum-seeking children's services, early help, education and

others. Issues can be raised directly by voluntary organisations and are often resolved quickly through joint action, for example:

- ensuring children have appropriate school uniforms.
- addressing gaps in school placements; or
- following up specific safeguarding concerns.

The number of meetings and arrangements had significantly reduced the risk of people “slipping through the net”.

The committee welcomed the proposal to establish a task and finish group on Borough of Sanctuary to examine this work in more depth. It was noted that, given the stage in the electoral cycle, this would be taken forward in the next council year, with detailed scope and membership to be agreed in due course.

8. WORK PROGRAMME

The committee noted the remaining work programme for 2025–26, including items scheduled for the 16 March 2026 meeting.

Meeting ended at 8.46 pm

CHAIR:

DATED: